

The Traumatic Experiences of Slaves Before They Crossed the Atlantic

Slavery was an involuntary surrender of liberty that for many lasted until the day they were laid to rest. For some, they lived, worked, and died in shackles, never having gained the liberty that had been taken from them. It was that uncertainty and longevity of slavery that added to its brutality, an emotional wound to accompany the physical ones. In a sense, the moment people are captured and their liberty is no longer their own, they are subjugated to their own psychological slavery before they become a slave to a master. Yet, for those who weren't born into slavery, the savagery of the slave trade did not start on the plantation. The transatlantic slave trade embarked approximately 12.5 million slaves from 1526 to 1866 (1), a majority to North and South America. Before they started a life of slavery, the slaves were captured, purchased, and transported at the hands of Europeans and Africans alike, yet these confoundingly brutal components of the slave trade and their psychological effects are largely overshadowed by the physical cruelty inflicted on slaves once they had reached their final destination, despite the arguably equivalent trauma factor of the Middle Passage, African barracoons, and initial loss of liberties. These events, capture, purchase, and transport, that facilitated the transition from free to slave were a traumatic and crucial part of the trade that highlighted the commencement of a life of brutality and for some the end of their life altogether.

Slave narratives are as equally valuable as they are uncommon. While up to 6000 are estimated to exist, less are accessible in archives and libraries, and less explore the pre-middle passage experience of the transatlantic slave trade (7). Among these limited narratives of Equiano Olaudah, Venture Smith, and Ottobah Cugoano, three prior slaves who were captured in West Africa as boys, sold into the transatlantic slave trade and left bondage at some point in their lives. Though the most detailed events and the majority of their biographies lay out their lives

after they had been captured, their introductory excerpts provide an insight into the pre-conditions of captives, the mechanisms of the trade, and the debilitating effects of it all. European accounts, however, are greater in quantity and while they may at times demonstrate a problematic bias in accounting the slave trade, they are also useful convenient primary sources. One of these accounts is that of abolitionist Alexander Falconbridge, recorded in his book *An Account of the Slave Trade on the Coast of Africa*. His time as a surgeon on slave ships permits an outsider's view of the inside horrors of the middle passage and transatlantic slave trade. Nonetheless, these sources are not without their limitations. All three men had similar African backgrounds characterized by relatively high status and proximity to the chief. The young age of Venture Smith raises questions on the reliability of his memory and new evidence challenges the validity of Equiano's narratives. Using these four firsthand accounts of the slave trade at its peak in the late 18th century, this paper examines the emotional response of captives and the traumatic factors that added to the overall negative experience of slavery, affecting the captives far before they had even reached their masters.

The traumatic experience of slavery is a widely accepted consequence of the transatlantic slave trade. There is enough evidence to concur that most slaves were treated cruelly, a common historical occurrence that has become present common knowledge, desensitizing many to the true horrors of slavery. Furthermore, literature and research regarding enslavement tend to focus more on the period of enslavement than the process in which they became enslaved. Studying the psychological torture and the emotional fragility of those sold into slavery, particularly how this capture and purchase process affected them, furthers the conversation on the commodification of slavery and allows for an improved and sympathetic understanding of the struggles of the trade. Sowande' Mustakeem explores this topic in her book *Slavery at Sea*:

Terror, Sex, and Sickness in the Middle Passage. She writes of the “manufacturing process” of the slaves and the subsequent deterioration of their bodies, physically and emotionally. She utilizes a plethora of sources and stories to “push back against the continued overlooking of many people and thematic details of brutalities.” The following argument mirrors that of Mustakeem, though it places less emphasis on the middle passage and physical subjugation relative to kidnapping and psychological terror.

The brutality that riddled Olaudah Equiano’s life was recorded in length in his autobiography, *The Interesting Narrative of the Life of Olaudah Equiano, Or Gustavus Vassa, The African*. His autobiography is one of the most well-known slave narratives to be published and established the slave narrative genre for years to come (2). In it, Equiano chronicled his life, detailing his experiences as a slave and freedman in the West Indies and Britain over a 30-year period. The first two chapters specifically talk about his homeland of Guinea and the circumstances under which Equiano was captured, a fraction of his bibliography that lays the foundation for the rest of his life. His life was recorded and published for multiple reasons, though the main motivation he stated was to “promote the interests of humanity” which would be achieved through the abolition of slavery. By the time of its publication in 1789, Olaudah Equiano was a well-known abolitionist in London, a position only bolstered by the publication of his autobiography, bringing him both popularity and wealth (3). While the spectacular retelling of his life reached the white audience and served its purpose as an influential piece of abolitionist literature, the expected benefits of fame and fortune challenge the sincerity of Equiano’s actions. Yet, his narrative remains an essential primary source for historians, a limited, first-person insight into the transatlantic slave trade.

The first, second, and third chapters of *The Interesting Narrative* exemplify slavery's depressive degradation of Equiano's spirit and the physical and emotional conquest of the slaves by the European masters. Before he goes into his personal experiences, Equiano declares an important distinction between the slave trade with the Europeans and the slave system within his homeland. Equiano reasons that the systematics of Guinean slavery still includes involuntary bondage, there is still some aspect of limited equality and respect that is not found in the West Indies. He implies the societal differences between the two, establishing Guinea as a society with slaves as opposed to the slave society that was the West Indies. Additionally, the slaves sold by the Guineans Equiano argued, were prisoners of war or those convicted of crimes, a code that Europeans didn't adhere to when they kidnapped whoever they pleased. The apparent absence of principles by the Europeans is sensible when from the perspective of the white men, slavery was an economic opportunity that reiterated their racial superiority. All Africans were the same, high-born or criminal; all could be slaves.

Despite Equiano's detest of European chattel slavery, he was taken from his home and enslaved by those of his own color. It isn't specified where or which people enslaved him, but the fact they spoke the same language implies it was likely in the same region from which he was kidnapped. The constant threat of kidnapping, demonstrated by a constant watch for kidnappers, pointed to the ongoing conflict between tribes as well as the shared kidnapping role of some Africans in the slave trade. Opposed to his descriptions of European interactions, Equiano seemed to repeatedly emphasize the kindness of his African masters, most if not all that can be assumed to be his countrymen as he did not yet mention his European masters until he first reached the slave ship and mentioned the same or similar tongues they shared. Almost all descriptions and anecdotal details of his time with these masters were relatively civil, even

pleasant at one point, a contrast to the cruelty of the “bad spirits” who tossed him on a slave ship in the most unimaginable of conditions. Their kindness may have struck his heart and embedded itself in his memory, but Equiano likely included these accounts purposefully as an antithesis to the slavery in the West Indies and as a consistent reminder that African slavery was not the same.

Olaudah Equiano’s specific way of writing his narrative and the contents he chose to include spoke to the external conflicts of slavery, but at its core, the narrative is exceptional not just for its writing, but its story. In Equiano’s case, he passed through many hands in the homeland, experiencing domestic African slavery before the seasoning of the West Indies. Everything that came before that, Equiano’s experiences in Chapter 2, spoke to the emotional and physical distress of the capture, transport, and purchase of slaves. Equiano’s experience on the slave ship produced a barrage of negative emotions as he was introduced to an entirely new people and an entirely new environment. The physical provocation of the overseers was used as a tool to instill fear, though once the threat was presented, it transitioned into a psychological weapon instead. Convinced the white men were spirits and cannibals, and constantly under the threat of flogging, he wrote “every circumstance I met with served only to render my state more painful, and heighten my apprehensions, and my opinion of the cruelty of the whites.” Equiano was overwhelmed by sorrow, at times considering the same suicidal fate of the other slaves. Slaves jumping overboard was a problem that alone demonstrated the effect of Middle Passage cruelty, for even before they could face the uncertain threats in a new world, they had decided that bondage was a fate worse than death. The internal struggles of longing, familial belonging, and uncertainty become more apparent. Captured slaves were left subjugated not just to their masters, but to the dread of losing their community and fear of what horrors awaited them, regardless of if they were sold within Africa or across the sea.

What slavery lacked in mercy, it compensated in imitation. Millions of slaves from the Western Coast of Africa met the same fate of bondage regardless of their background and the “sameness” (7) that plagues many slave narratives demonstrates this. Venture Smith’s *A Narrative of the Life and Adventures of Venture, A Native of Africa: But resident above sixty years in the United States of America* details his life as a son of a prince and native Guinean who was also captured, sold into slavery, and later bought his freedom. His autobiography, published a year after Equiano’s death in 1798, was the first slave narrative to be published in the United States (5). His narrative was written with abolitionist motivations, as in most slave narratives, Smith stating in the closing “my freedom is a privilege which nothing else can equal. (6).” Venture Smith died shortly after his bibliography was published, never garnering as much popularity as Equiano’s narrative, though just as valuable of a source. Smith focuses a majority of his 32-page narrative on his time in New England as a slave and freedman alongside his struggles as an African-American, though the beginning portion speaks to the traumatic scars left by the trade.

Venture Smith’s path to slavery was telling of the African warfare that facilitated the triangle trade and the domestic role of Africans as producers of slaves and additional practitioners of cruelty. Unlike Equiano, Smith’s capture was a result of a large African raid as opposed to a small group of kidnappers, though just as, if not more traumatizing. Consistent with Equiano’s narrative and the transatlantic slave trade as a whole, Europeans and Africans both played a role in Smith’s integration into chattel slavery. Six-year-old Smith watched his father fight the invaders to surrender, suffer at the hands of torture, and subsequently succumb to death, though never revealing the location of the fortune they had sought to kill him for.

He had observed such an obscene act of violence at such a young age while simultaneously suffering a sudden loss of family, a support system that he had been reliant on not simply for emotional needs, but also practical ones as a result of his youth. Similar to Equiano and Cugoano, Smith was kidnapped before he reached adulthood, although he was by far the youngest of them and certainly the most vulnerable. While it was his youth that saved him from the seasoning of the West Indies, it also was his youth that amplified his experience as traumatic. While he watched his father's death from the bushes, the helplessness of a child intertwined with the profound powerlessness of a slave. The acknowledgment that a captive was no longer their own, that their fate lay in the hands of another, deducted them to something less than a person. Slavery was the depravity of physical and emotional freedom, a conquest of body and soul, that preyed on the weak and strong alike, demonstrating the true helplessness of those stuck in bondage. Chattel slavery in particular degraded the means of a person from a human to property, a currency or economic tool in which power was only physical and even that was used for the benefit of a master. This dehumanization, however, has become an accepted consequence of slavery, desensitizing the present to the individual horrors of the past.

The capture is a crucial moment in a slave's life, marking the transition from free to enslaved and indefinitely revoking their sense of humanity. Though the lengthy period of cruelty brought on by slavery dominated Smith's life, his capture was a pivotal moment, introducing him to the brutal consequences of African warfare and the hardships that would ensue as a result of 18th-century mercantilism. This curious determination of his father perhaps moved Smith in his own endeavors, displaying unmatched diligence that would allow him to buy the freedom he lost the day his father lost his life. More likely, it intimidated the young boy, introducing him to the horrors of what was to come as a life as a slave. This particular memory had struck Smith even in

old age, as he wrote “the shocking scene is to this day fresh in my mind, and I have often been overcome while thinking on it.”

Ottobah Cugoano, or John Stuart, was a former slave and prominent writer who had spent a relatively short time enslaved, allowing him to spend much of his adulthood cultivating his abolitionist writings. In a narrative strikingly similar to Olaudah Equiano’s, Cugoano records his path to freedom from the time he was captured on the Gold Coast, concurrently denouncing slavery and calling for the immediate emancipation of slaves. Cugoano wrote *Thoughts and Sentiments on the Evil and Wicked Traffic of the Slavery and Commerce of the Human Species* with the same motivations as Equiano, though did not reach the same international acclaim in literature, likely for its more radical message of immediate emancipation and Equiano’s superior writing skill. Despite its lesser prominence, his testimony reveals the dreadful ethos of his experience and his struggles as a diasporic migrant. Cugoano’s autobiography and call to action laid out his abolitionist arguments skillfully, also inviting readers to examine his impassioned experience as a captive as well as a slave.

Cugoano’s pivotal capture was at the age of 13 years old at the hands of kidnappers while he played in a field with other children. Cugoano’s introduction greater emphasizes the mass emotions that affected the slaves collectively compared to the other narratives. The kidnapping of this Fanti boy from his home in Agimaque resembled the stories of so many others, and Cugoano makes note of the shared destitution felt by the thousands of other captives who shared his sorrows. The castle dungeons in which Cugoano was imprisoned no doubt held slave contempt as it did fear, seething anger towards the situation, towards those who captured them, and towards those who would buy them, anger that could foster violence and action. On

Cugoano's ship, the captives, already jaded by the conditions of captivity, had decided to burn the ship and perish. So essential was freedom and so traumatic was their captivity that it pushed them to suicide. Like many, the preference of death to captivity demonstrated not just a rejection of a life of bondage and suffering, but also an act of prideful preservation at the expense of the physical body. Their plan was foiled however by an enslaved woman who told one of the headmen of the ship with whom she was sleeping. Cugoano offers an additional female perspective not present in the other slave narratives. Betrayal by a countrywoman sparked remorse and anger in the captives, but they were not the only victims. Though it was unspecified whether she gave up this information or her body willingly, consent is nonexistent at the tail end of a whip. Her relationships with the sailors were far from romantic, instead, it was an example of the physical subjugation of female slaves through sexual assault. What Cugaono didn't address was the emotional subjugation that coupled with the traumatic sexual experience, but was obvious in his anger towards the "dirty filthy sailors" that often lied upon the African women.

Yet, even stronger than anger was trepidation. The greatest emotions felt by the captive were fear and horror, the most frequently used descriptors in Cugoano's opening chapter as he describes his capture, transport to the coast, and voyage to the Americas. He described fearful uncertainty upon entering the presence of several white people, a harrowing threat of cannibalism and danger inciting intense terror. Cugoano wrote "all my help was cries and tears, and these could not avail; nor suffered long, till one succeeding woe, and dread, swelled up another. Brought from a state of innocence and freedom, and, in a barbarous and cruel manner, conveyed to a state of horror and slavery." They were demeaned and dehumanized with negligence, left in filth and chained like animals, physical subjugation that could degrade their

confidence and morph how captives viewed themselves. Whether for the purpose of abolitionist sympathy or a sincere reflection of his trauma, Cugoano somberly details the lingering feelings of his capture and the middle passage atrocities, writing “the grievous thoughts which I then felt, still pant in my heart; though my fears and tears have long since subsided.” Even in his days of regained freedom, Cugoano could not shake the bleak impression left by his journey after capture. Though he faced equally cruel treatment upon his disembarkment in the Americas, there was no comparison to the initial realization that liberty was a thing of the past.

In contrast to the slave narratives of Equiano, Smith, and Cugoano, *An Account of the Slave Trade on the Coast of Africa*, while abolitionist literature, is written by Alexander Falconbridge, a European who was never enslaved, but worked on multiple slave ships as a surgeon. With this outsider view, however, is the inability to explain the casual cruelty of the trade as a victim, only to speak on it as a spectator. Nonetheless, his sympathetic writings reveal that even an observer can see the brutality of the trade and the anguish felt by the captives. His repetitive observance of the slave trade from the outside allows an examination of the methodologies and interworkings of the trade as opposed to a single experience.

Falconbridge lays out the atrocities of purchase and the Middle Passage, detailing the countless practices of the slavers and the sailors during his multiple journeys across the Atlantic. He also included stories from African men and women, suggesting that Falconbridge was curious about or took pity upon the captives and conversed with them on more than one occasion. He referred to them as “unhappy wretches” and “unhappy beings” and demonstrated sympathy towards their situation, though never doing much of anything about it. Falconbridge also addresses the sexual deviancy of the sailors and the normality of suicide consistent with the

narratives of Equiano, Smith, and Cugoano. At times, the two intertwined, and the sexual attention of the sailors would lead women to jump ship. Oftentimes in the case of rape, sexual dominance meant the dissolution of both choice and pleasure, subjecting the African women to violations emotionally and physically. Falconbridge, in an attempt to distance himself from the immorality of the slave trade, reasons most surgeons on Guinean coast ships are confined by their economic position. Nevertheless, his condemnation of slavery is apparent, and he chastises the commodification of the captives and calls for the abolition of the trade multiple times throughout.

The slaves' experiences are nearly the same, yet different in every way, in the people they left, the people they came across, and most importantly, the personal identity of the person captured. Every moment from then would morph the slaves into who they were, regardless of how they chose to react to their suffering. Nonetheless, slaves are grouped together by their slave experience, regardless of their individuality. Again one should consider the "sameness" that characterizes these three slave narratives as an inherent resemblance as a result of the great magnitude and length of the trade. In this way, this homogeneous cruelty of the trade created interchangeable chattel, dehumanizing slaves to the level of manufactured products and standard currency. For Olaudah Equiano, Venture Smith, and Ottobah Cugoano, however, it is their similarities, that sets them apart. These former slaves, through work or luck, were able to not only find liberation but write about it as well.

These slave narratives, despite their prominence and value to the abolitionist movement, are not without their limitations. It is because they were free that they were able to write their narratives, but for many slaves, they could never afford to buy their liberty or were fortunate

enough to fall into the hands of a master willing to free them. They also all came from a place of relatively high status in their home countries, and each was characterized by proximity to their chief. Whether this relationship is of any significance is questionable since they all ended up amongst tons of different slaves of different backgrounds, but it provides a limited view of the pre-captivity life. With Smith specifically, his young age leads to uncertainty regarding the reliability of his accounts. He was six years old when his village was raided, yet he recounts his experience with surprising accuracy. On the other hand, the sheer traumatic effect of being captured, separated from his family, and sold may have ingrained the memory in his head, but there is no guarantee of accuracy. The most drastic of limitations, however, is the contemporary challenge of the validity of Equiano's narrative, instead claiming he may have been born in South Carolina. Equiano and Cugoana as writers and members of the black upper class in Britain were well acquainted, and the possible fabrication of his narrative and South Carolina birth certificate would explain the striking similarities between the two autobiographies.

In all of the sources, the slave narratives, and Falconbridge's account, there is a consistent theme of psychological challenge that coincided with the physical intimidation and domination of captives. The kidnapping and transporting aspects of the trade initiated the embarkment of 12 million slaves into captivity or to their deaths, the pivotal moment that changed their lives and the first phase of cruelty in a world that did not care for them. Both the experience of being captured to be sold as a slave and the challenges in captivity are generally deemphasized in general education, leading to the ignorance of the complex emotional and psychological factors that encompassed the slave trade. While it is important to acknowledge that the of slaves was a

relatively short period in a slave's life, they largely affected the slave experience. For those captured directly from Africa, the initial horrors of the trade forever shaped the slave whose freedom only existed in comfortable memories. Apart from the collective suffering of the slaves, each captive had a similar, yet completely individual experience that shaped the way they acted. Had Equiano not been separated from his sister, had Smith not watched his father die, had the sailors on Cugoano's ship not slept with that woman, perhaps their stories would be more different. Perhaps the omission of the physical actions of murder, separation, and rape may have allowed for the emotional regeneration of familial connection, community, and dignity in the face of cruelty, a dilution of the brutality of the trade. It is the introduction of the story that sets the stage for the rest of the book. The enslaved were not novels, nor were they the narratives they may have written, but real people whose physical wounds may have healed, but were left with the traumatic memory of losing everything.

12-15 pages

1. Cover page
 - a. Chicago style cover ← google it
2. Introduction
 - a. Introduce topic
 - b. Historical context
 - c. Sources used
 - d. Research question
 - e. thesis statement
3. Body
 - a. 4 parts, one for each source
 - i. Context, discussion of source, analysis
 - ii. What does this say about argument or research question
 - b. Comparison of sources
 - i. What does it tell us collectively
 - ii. Compare contrast
 - iii. Limitations of sources
 1. Equiano: for money and fame or to help the cause? Was he even african?
 2. Venture Smith was 6 years old, dictated but not written by himself
 3. All of them were either royalty or well off, how many became upper middle-class clike Equiano and Cugoano
 - c. What have others said about the topic
 - i. Use of secondary sources
 1. Who more to blame/crueler the Africans who sold them or the Europeans
 2. Trauma in kidnapping
 - ii. Do I agree or disagree?
4. Conclusion
 - a. Summarize the argument or topic
 - b. Why does this matter?
 - c. Tie introduction to conclusion

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barracoon

1. <https://www.pbs.org/wnet/african-americans-many-rivers-to-cross/history/how-many-slaves-landed-in-the-us/>
2. <https://slaveryandremembrance.org/people/person/?id=PP003>
3. https://www.jstor.org/stable/25501614?seq=1#metadata_info_tab_contents
4. https://www.gutenberg.org/files/15399/15399-h/15399-h.htm#FNanchor_A_1 footnote A, ch 1
5. <https://blogs.loc.gov/loc/2021/09/venture-smith-the-first-slave-narrative/>
6. Page 31 venture smith
7. https://www.jstor.org/stable/2930678?origin=crossref&seq=3#metadata_info_tab_contents

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